



**free will
and
determinism**

against
compatibilist
free will

against
incompatibilist
free will

More precisely, our topic is the relationship between freedom of the will and determinism, and a cluster of arguments which seem to show that free will is incompatible with both determinism and indeterminism, and hence impossible.

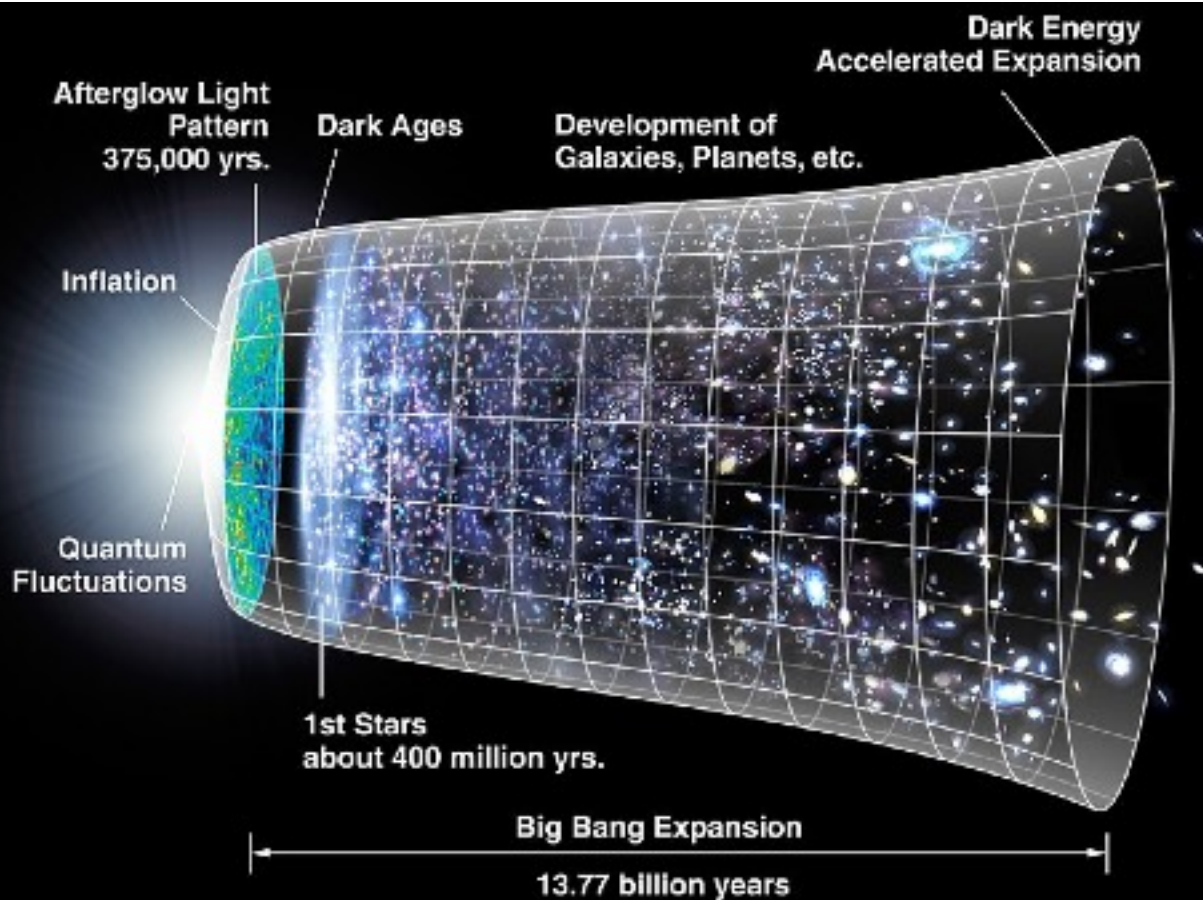
What is 'determinism'?

Consider a timeline of the history of the universe.

What determinism says is that, given a full specification of the state of the universe at one time, the laws of nature tell you exactly what will happen at every later time.

Our topic today is the challenge to free will posed by determinism.

"Determinism is the thesis that only one continuation of the state of things at a given moment is consistent with the laws of nature."



One picturesque way to think of it is in terms of ‘rolling back history.’
Imagine that we roll back the clock to the year 1500. If determinism is true,
then — so long as we hold fixed the laws of nature — history since then
would unfold in precisely the way that it has.

Sometimes people use 'determinism' as a name for the thesis that there is no free will, so that determinism rules out free will by definition. That is not how we are using the term. Determinism is a thesis about the laws of the nature. It is then an open question whether we could have free will in a world with deterministic laws.

We are **not** assuming that determinism is true. We are just explaining what it would mean for determinism to be true.

If we are not assuming that determinism is true, then why are we talking about it? The answer is that it is a good way to raise a question about the conditions under which free will is possible.

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2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

about whether @.

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

C. If determinist is true, then no one has any

varlatatie + the last of the

then DECISION. (4,5)

then DECISION happens. (3)

1. No one has any choice about events which

5. No one has any choice about what the laws



theorie about the fact that if DNR

3. If determined, the only one

if P , then Q , then one has any choice



choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

happened in the distant past.

future is not just what the state of the

of interest.

7. If none has about choice about whether P ,

and none has any choice about whether,

4. If determinism is true, the laws of

6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

This argument seems to show that the

combination of four - that No

choice principle, and determinism

rules out free will.

one has any choice about the past, no

choice about the laws of nature, then no

Since the first three of these theses

seem quite plausible, the argument

hence that free will is incompatible with

dearminism.

seems to show that if determinism is

true, there are no free actions — and







2. If Libertarianism is true, there is no free

Wili.

1. Freewill is incompatible with determinism.

0: There is no fire will.



Real/|the master argument:

in free will, and find the consequent argument persuasive, it looks

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe

tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).



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A red circular button with a slight drop shadow, containing the text "against incompatibilist free will" in white, lowercase, sans-serif font.

against
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reality of free will.

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the



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Wili.

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0. There is no fire in.



Compatibility believers in free will reject premise (1). An incompatibilist

believe in free will rejects premise (2).

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2)

or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one

for (2), and one for (3).

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text "against compatibilist free will" in white, bold, sans-serif font.

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